



Photograph Jyotbeet Singh

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Beat That!

Digit Caption

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yield significant returns in terms of user data stored on the phones. Already, hackers have breached the security features of the iPhone (they've unlocked it from the AT&T network), and have installed third-party applications. Though these hacks have been rendered ineffective by firmware upgrades, determined attacks on the basic platform would pose actual, serious threats that would need more than a simple upgrade. Attacks could involve the spread of mobile worms, which could render individual handsets useless, or the creation of a vast mobile botnet for sending out spam mails and SMSes. This scenario is now a distinct possibility because of the ubiquity of the iPhone.

2008 could very well see the release of security products targeted at Macs. Bad news for fanboys, but reassuring for corporates and businesses who are still leery of trusting valuable data to systems that do not have security features.

WIKI-KILLER?

A Knol of Wisdom

Of late, Google has been diversifying from its core search business, getting into areas like telecom and security. Now it's knowledge management and distribution à la Wikipedia that the Big G has set its eyes on.

Google has announced the launch of a new project called Knol, which aims to be a repository of the world's information. The blueprint for Knol is to allow experts to write definitive articles in their field of expertise. On the face of it, this sounds like Wikipedia. But there are some differences—each topic or page on the Knol, called “a knol” (a unit of knowledge) will be effectively owned by the author, who will not remain anonymous. There might be multiple knols on the same subject, and they may only be edited by the

author or with the author's permission. This model borrows from Squidoo, a content management site that lets authors own their pages. Google will not act the editor in any way, and there will be nothing like an official knol for each topic. It aims only to provide the tools and the server space. Knol, currently in private beta, is open to users by invitation only.

Google will also host ads on each knol. The upside is that authors will get a significant share of the revenues (the actual percentage is being worked out). Industry watchers are, however, divided on the feasibility of another knowledge repository, and are also suspicious of Google's aims. It's a known fact that for many searches, the relevant Wikipedia entry comes at the top of the results page. When users click on that link, they go to a site where Google cannot put in any ads... This means a potential loss of millions of dollars in ad revenue. Again, there is the danger

that driven by ad revenues, there might be a proliferation of knols on commercially-viable topics like microprocessor architecture or fashion design, and less about the Peace of Westphalia and Sumerian civilisation.

The most basic argument is, however, that since editing rights are locked, knols might contain biased viewpoints, or that they might contain outdated information. But there are certain arguments in favour of this new model. For one, since authors will no longer be anonymous, they might keep their knols objective and updated. Unlike Wikipedia, where each page can be modified by all and sundry and it is often difficult to separate the wheat from the chaff, Knol could result in pieces of authoritative work.

But then again, knols can be searched by search engines, and there are fears that Google might tweak its algorithms so knols feature at the top of search results. However,